

Ornaments

In aesthetic terms, anything “ornamental” is usually thought of as purely decorative and not necessarily functional. Similarly, ornaments in music are used to decorate, embellish, or emphasize a melody.

SEE ALSO

◀ 18–19 Notes on the staff

Analyzing melodies 108–109 ▶

Orchestral forms 170–171 ▶

The Baroque period 208–209 ▶

Grace notes

A grace note is a simple ornament, which merely decorates the melody. It is notated in smaller type and is placed immediately before the note it ornaments. Attached to the main melodic tone with a small slur, it usually has a diagonal line across its stem and can be performed in several different ways.

68 ▽ Acciaccatura

This grace note is played as fast as possible, on, or just before, the beat, producing a “crushed” effect. The aural emphasis is on the main melody note.

Written Played

Written Played

Written Played

Written Played

69 △ Appoggiatura

Appoggiatura grace notes are half the value of the main melody note. This gives them a higher importance in the melody.

Turns

A turn is a quick, smooth ornament. First the note itself is played, then the note above, back to the main note, followed by the note below, and lastly the main note again. It may be performed as five equal tones, or fitted in quickly and rhythmically at the end of the melody note's value.

70

▷ Turns on the staff

Occasionally composers write out the turn in the desired rhythm—slower equal tones, or quickly executed in a triplet rhythm—to ensure performance consistency.

Notated with a sideways S-shaped symbol.

Simple passage ornamented with a turn, ending on a half note.

Written

Played

The turn returns to the main note before continuing with the melody.